WEEK 01 / HISTORICAL FOUNDATIONS

Your Video Game Story & Introduction to Gaming History

Share personal gaming experiences.

This week, we introduce the course by sharing personal gaming experiences. Students will reflect on their own history with video games, discussing favorite games, memorable moments, and how gaming has influenced their lives.

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11 RESOURCES / 1 TOPIC

TOPIC 01

Origins, Genres, and Personal Histories

REQUIRED

Maine Calling: Video Games

AUDIO | 51 MIN

https://www.mainepublic.org/show/maine-calling/2024-12-02/video-games

This radio segment from an episode of Maine Calling on Maine Public discusses the integration of video games into mainstream culture and how their definition has expanded over time. Featuring academic panelists, the program explores how games have shifted from simple arcade machines to complex narrative and social experiences like Minecraft or mobile brain teasers like Wordle. The discussion also highlights the role of video games in anthropological and historical study, noting their significance as cultural artifacts. It emphasizes that modern gaming isn't just for "hardcore gamers" but includes anyone playing mainstream mobile games or participating in digital social hubs.

LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.
LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.
LO 4: Students will be able to discuss ethical concerns surrounding gaming, including issues related to violence, addiction, monetization practices, labor concerns, and virtual identities.
LO 7: Students will be able to express informed perspectives on gaming in written reflections and class discussions, connecting course content to broader social and cultural contexts.

REQUIRED

Video Game Invasion: The History of a Global Obsession [2004]

YOUTUBE | 91 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=O4dPSOncwVQ

This documentary from 2004 is hosted by skateboarding legend Tony Hawk and traces the evolution of the video game industry from a primitive electronic novelty into a multi-billion dollar global entertainment

powerhouse that rivals Hollywood. It highlights how the industry was built by visionary pioneers like Nolan Bushnell and Shiro Miyamoto, who transitioned gaming from simple dots on a screen to immersive, character-driven narratives and complex social simulations. The video further explores the cyclical nature of the business, documenting early hardware wars, the catastrophic market crash of 1983, and the eventual resurgence led by Japanese innovation and personal computing. Beyond commercial success, the source examines the cultural impact and controversies of the medium, detailing how video games have influenced military training, sparked intense legislative debates over virtual violence, and fostered massive online communities.

LO 1: Students will be able to explain the historical development of video games, from early arcade games to contemporary digital gaming platforms.

REQUIRED

50 Years of Gaming History, by Revenue Stream (1970-2020)

INFOGRAPHIC AND ARTICLE | 6 MIN

https://www.visualcapitalist.com/50-years-gaming-history-revenue-stream/

This infographic provides a 50-year financial overview of the gaming industry, tracing its growth into the world's highest-earning media sector, generating an estimated $165 billion in 2020. It outlines major historical eras, from the initial arcade boom of the 70s to the tech race between Nintendo, Sony, and Microsoft in the 80s and 90s. The current era is defined by an "Online Boom," where subscription services, digital storefronts, and a massive $85 billion mobile market dominate revenue. A few highlights:

By 1982, the arcade market was generating more money than the pop music industry and the box office combined.
Sony's PlayStation (1994) was the first console in history to sell over 100 million units, largely due to its use of CD-ROMs.
- Grand Theft Auto V holds the record for the fastest-selling entertainment product, reaching $1 billion in revenue in just three days.

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LO 8: Students will be able to discuss potential future trends in gaming, reflecting on emerging technologies, cultural shifts, and player expectations.

EXPLORE FURTHER

I Played 100 Years Of Video Games

YOUTUBE

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=FBmybY8W8uU

This video from YouTube creator Sambucha provides a casual chronological journey through video game history, featuring a playthrough of landmark titles starting from 1940's Nim. It highlights the progression from simple blips on a screen, like Tennis for Two, to the "Golden Age" triggered by the release of the NES and iconic characters like Mario and Link. The video also touches on the "console wars" of the 90s and the eventual rise of high-fidelity modern gaming on platforms like the PlayStation 5 and Xbox Series X. There is some overlap with the History of Video Games documentary, but this is a more recent and personal take on the subject from a popular YouTuber. A few highlights:

The *Atari game ET* is widely considered the worst video game ever and the video repeats the common claim that it was so poorly received that it tanked the American video game economy, leading to Japan's dominance in the industry. We'll be exploring this more in a couple of weeks.
Nintendo's first attempt at a video game was Radar Scope in 1979, which succeeded in Japan but was a

complete failure in the United States.
- The game Snake became a cultural phenomenon after being pre-installed on Nokia mobile phones in 1997.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

The Birth of BASIC

YOUTUBE

https://youtu.be/WYPNjSoDrqw?si=TVzqzV7JnbDy_VUn

Not directly about games, but ties into my story. This video details the creation of the BASIC programming language at Dartmouth College 50 years ago, driven by the "nutty idea" that all undergraduate students should be computer literate. Professors John Kemeny and Thomas Kurtz developed the language and the Dartmouth Time-Sharing System (DTSS) to provide students with immediate, simple access to computing resources. Remarkably, the complex software was primarily written by undergraduate students, proving that simple high-level languages could be compiled and run simultaneously by multiple users. A few highlights:

Before getting their own computer, Dartmouth had to transport punch cards to MIT every two weeks via train, resulting in a data transfer rate of only 1.67 bits per second.
To pay for their first computer (the LGP-30) without a budget, the college classified it as "furniture" to use funds set aside for furnishings.

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1981: How Computer Graphics will Change the World

YOUTUBE

https://youtu.be/W8-54-9J9ns?si=GtVJ2EWE-1PZGWfg

A fun historical look at early predictions about graphics technology, this BBC Horizon documentary from 1981 traces the origins and rapid evolution of computer graphics, beginning with early military applications like the Whirlwind computer and Ivan Sutherland's pioneering "Sketchpad". It explores the development of early video games like Pong and Space War, while also highlighting how graphics technology was being utilized in flight simulators, 3D animation, and molecular biology to model DNA. The video emphasizes that the "magic" of realistic computer imagery largely flowered at the University of Utah, where students developed mathematical formulas for shading, texture, and curved surfaces. A few highlights:

Pong was so successful in its initial consumer test that the machine "broke" simply because its coin box was completely filled with quarters.
Early 3D animation was so labor-intensive that a single frame could take 7 minutes to compute, and some conventional animators initially refused to work with computers.

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LO 5: Students will gain insights into how technologies like artificial intelligence, virtual reality, and online connectivity shape gaming experiences.

EXPLORE FURTHER

The Definitive Guide to Video Game Genres and Game Types

ARTICLE | 60 MIN

https://codakid.com/video-game-genres/

Helpful for distinguishing game genres. A bit long, so consider skimming or bookmarking and using as a reference. This comprehensive encyclopedia defines and categorizes the vast array of video game genres and subgenres used in the industry today. It provides detailed descriptions of core categories like Action, RPG, and Strategy, while also exploring specialized types such as "Idle Games" and "Advergames". The guide serves as an educational tool, explaining how specific gameplay mechanics-like the "blobber" movement in first-person party RPGs-define different categories. A few highlights:

4X strategy games are defined by four specific goals: Explore, Expand, Exploit, and Exterminate.
"Exergames" (fitness games) became particularly important during the COVID-19 pandemic as a tool for rehabilitation and physical activity.
- Advergames are promotional tools created specifically to market a brand, with examples including games for McDonald's and Chipotle.

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LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Boss Fight Books

WEB SITE

https://bossfightbooks.com/

Boss Fight Books is a publishing series that produces long-form, scholarly books focusing on specific classic video games. The collection spans a wide range of titles, from early hits like Galaga and Super Mario Bros. to modern narratives such as Red Dead Redemption and Outer Wilds. A featured upcoming title in the series is Age of Empires by Richard Moss, which uses interviews with 29 former Ensemble and Microsoft staff to tell the story of the game's development.

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The Game Beat: Observations and Lessons from Two Decades Writing about Games by Kyle Orland

BOOK

https://press.etc.cmu.edu/books/game-beat

The Game Beat is a collection of over 80 columns by journalist Kyle Orland that examines the history and ethics of the gaming press. Published through Carnegie Mellon University's ETC Press, the book explores the evolution of video game journalism over two decades, covering the transition from print magazines to digital media. It addresses critical industry issues such as the importance of review scores and the ethics surrounding paid press junkets. The book offers deep media analysis of how the young but rapidly growing game industry is covered by critics. You can download the book for free in PDF format.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Let's Buy Commodore®

YOUTUBE PLAYLIST

https://www.youtube.com/show/VLPL7QScsJIdNE2O3TDlOxYsJB3bazVoBCi7?sbp=KgtsTjhyNExSY09YY0AB

Follow Peri Fractic and crew as set embark on a mission to rescue the most beloved tech brand of all time, as they proclaim, "Let's Buy Commodore!"

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EXPLORE FURTHER

They Really Didn’t Have to Go This Hard for the Cyberpunk 2077 Edition of the Commodore 64

ARTICLE | 2 MIN

https://gizmodo.com/they-really-didnt-have-to-go-this-hard-for-the-cyberpunk-2077-edition-of-the-commodore-64-2000803455

This article highlights a unique hardware collaboration between Commodore and CD Projekt Red, introducing a specialized version of the classic 1980s computer rebranded as the Commodore 77. The author establishes a historical connection between the legacy of the Commodore 64 and the origins of the cyberpunk genre, noting how early tech influenced the tabletop RPG that eventually became the hit video game. While the new machine features modern internal upgrades such as a 77MHz processor and increased memory, it maintains broad compatibility with the vast library of original software and peripherals. Ultimately, the article serves as both a nostalgic deep dive and a product announcement for a stylized collector's item designed to appeal to retro enthusiasts and fans of the sci-fi franchise.

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